

thiscode — Easiest Setup Guide

Even first-time users finish in 5 steps

Who this guide is for

OK even if you've barely used a terminal. Copy + paste + Enter, one line at a time.

What you need

- An internet-connected computer (Mac / Linux / WSL — Windows native to come later)
- Claude Code (install from <https://claude.com/code>)
- 5~30 minutes (depending on the Tier you pick)

Written 2026-05-13 | v1.0

1. Before You Begin — The Whole Flow at a Glance

In one line, the flow looks like this:

0. Environment check

→

1. Plugin install

→

2. Search MCP

→

3. Obsidian branch

→

4. GraphRAG (optional)

→

5. Healthcheck

Each step ends with a ✓ **This is what success looks like** checkpoint. If it fails, stop at that step — don't move on.

1.1. What is the km plugin's 4-Tier search?

The km plugin's 4-Tier search tries GraphRAG, Obsidian CLI, vault-search MCP, then ripgrep. When a tier is unavailable or returns insufficient results, it falls back to the next one. ThisCode's installer scripts install the local tools.

- **Tier 4 — ripgrep** (default, 0-min setup) — literal string match, very fast
- **Tier 2 — obsidian-cli** (3-min setup, Obsidian users only) — uses Obsidian's index
- **Tier 3 — vault-search MCP** (5-min setup) — embedding-based semantic search
- **Tier 1 — GraphRAG** (25-min setup, advanced) — LLM + graph, the most accurate

Tip — For the fastest start, just Tier 4 + 2 (path 3-A) is enough. Try GraphRAG (path 4-C) once you're comfortable.

2. Step 0 — Wizard entry (recommended in v2.1)

The easiest path is the `thiscode init wizard` — it auto-detects vault / tools / resources and recommends 8 phases.

```
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/claude-discode-init.sh
```

What the wizard asks:

- Which Tier's search tool should I install?
- Install GraphRAG? (recommended for 500+ notes — optional anytime)
- Mode R preflight? (recommended for 2000+ notes, read-only)

For step-by-step manual installation, see steps 1~5 below (for users who don't go through the wizard).

3. Step 0 — Environment check (2 min)

First check what is already installed. Open a terminal (Mac = Spotlight cmd+space → search “Terminal” / WSL = the Ubuntu app / Linux = Ctrl+Alt+T) and copy + paste + Enter, one line at a time.

3.1. 0-1. Check Node.js

```
node --version
```

✓ **Success looks like** — a number such as v18.17.0 is fine

✗ **If it fails** — if you see “command not found”, install the LTS version (v18 or v20) from <https://nodejs.org> and restart your terminal

3.2. 0-2. Check jq

```
jq --version
```

✓ **Success looks like** — output like jq-1.6

✗ **If it fails** — Mac: brew install jq / Ubuntu / WSL: sudo apt install jq

3.3. 0-3. Check git

```
git --version
```

✓ **Success looks like** — git version 2.x.x

✗ **If it fails** — Mac: xcode-select --install / Ubuntu / WSL: sudo apt install git

4. Step 1 — Plugin install (2 min)

```
mkdir -p ~/.claude/plugins
git clone https://github.com/treylom/ThisCode ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode
```

✓ Success looks like

```
Cloning into '/Users/.../thiscode'...
remote: Enumerating objects: ...
Receiving objects: 100% (...), done.
```

✗ If it fails

- “Permission denied” → check write permission for `mkdir ~/.claude/plugins`
- “already exists” → already installed. Update with `cd ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode && git pull`

5. Step 2 — Search MCP install (5 min, recommended)

```
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/install-vault-search.sh --apply
claude mcp list | grep vault-search
```

✓ Success looks like — a single vault-search line in the output

✗ If it fails

- `claude: command not found` → Claude Code is not installed. <https://claude.com/code>
- `npm install fails` → try `nvm use 18` or `nvm install 18`

Important — Restart Claude Code once after install (`exit` then relaunch).

6. Step 3 — Do you use Obsidian? 🤔

Yes → 3-A (Install Obsidian CLI, 3 min)

No → 3-B (Skip, go straight to Step 4)

6.1. 3-A. Install Obsidian CLI (Obsidian users only)

```
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thisthings/scripts/install-obsidian-cli.sh
which obsidian-cli
```

✓ **Success looks like** — a path such as `/usr/local/bin/obsidian-cli`

✗ **If it fails** — add `sudo`, or see the manual-install section in the README

6.2. 3-B. Skip — it still works without Obsidian ✓

- Only Tier 2 (Obsidian CLI) is skipped among the 4 tiers
- Tiers 1 / 3 / 4 still run normally — about 80% of the functionality remains
- Move on directly to Step 4

7. Step 4 — Going all the way to GraphRAG? 🚀

Pick one of three options:

Choice	Who?	Time
4-A	Skip for now, get started fast (up to Tier 2)	0 min
4-B	Docker-comfortable user	10 min
4-C	Want local Python + direct debugging	25 min

7.1. 4-A. Skip for now ✅

→ Jump straight to Step 5

7.2. 4-B. Easy install via Docker

```
docker --version
docker pull ghcr.io/treylom/ThisCode-graphrag:v1.0
docker run -d -p 8400:8400 -v ~/vault:/vault \
  --name thiscode-graphrag \
  ghcr.io/treylom/ThisCode-graphrag:v1.0
curl localhost:8400/health
```

✓ **Success looks like** — {"status":"ok"}

✗ If it fails

- Docker not installed → <https://docs.docker.com/get-docker/>
- Port 8400 conflict → switch to -p 8401:8400 and set env GRAPHRAG_URL=http://localhost:8401

7.3. 4-C. Local Python install

```
python3 --version
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/install-graphrag.sh --apply
curl localhost:8400/health
```

Install time 5~10 min + initial indexing 15 min = about 25 min total.

✓ **Success looks like** — {"status":"ok"}

8. Step 5 — Verify everything's OK 🎉

```
bash ~/.claude/plugins/thiscode/scripts/healthcheck.sh
```

✓ **Success looks like — SKIP markers reflect your choices**

```
thiscode healthcheck v1.0
-----
✓ Tier 4 (ripgrep)   : OK
✓ Tier 3 (MCP)       : OK
○ Tier 2 (CLI)       : SKIP (no Obsidian — chose 3-B)
○ Tier 1 (GraphRAG) : SKIP (chose 4-A)
-----
all required checks passed ✓
```

✗ **If it fails**

```
cat ~/.thiscode-setup.log
```

Copy this file's contents into a GitHub Issue: <https://github.com/treylom/ThisCode/issues/new?template=setup-failure.yml>

9. Try it out

Inside Claude Code:

```
/thiscode:help
```

For vault search, install the km plugin first:

```
claude plugin marketplace add treylom/tofukyung-plugins
claude plugin install km@tofukyung-plugins
/km:search "hello first search"
```

Congratulations! 🎉

10. Frequently Asked Questions

10.1. Q1. Can I stop in the middle of setup?

Yes. Each step is independent, so even just steps 1-3 give you working Tier 4 (ripgrep) search.

10.2. Q2. macOS / Linux / Windows / WSL — all supported?

macOS / Linux / WSL are verified. Windows native is on the roadmap (WSL recommended for now).

10.3. Q3. I'm a student — what about cost?

- Tier 4 (ripgrep) + Tier 2 (Obsidian) = 100% free
- Tier 3 (MCP) = free (inside your Claude Code subscription)
- Tier 1 (GraphRAG) = OpenAI / Anthropic API calls → roughly \$0.5~5 for an initial indexing, depending on vault size

10.4. Q4. I already use just obsidian-cli — what's the difference?

See the 5-axis benchmark in the README. An earlier ThisCode guide note described a GraphRAG recall uplift over the then-Obsidian CLI baseline, but the archived 2026-05-13 result skipped Tier 1 and Tier 2 under its legacy engine IDs (vault-search MCP used 2, Obsidian CLI used 3), so it does not substantiate a percentage. The note is historical and is not a current km plugin runtime measurement.

- Current trade-off: Tier 2 Obsidian CLI is a lightweight local option, while Tier 1 GraphRAG adds semantic/graph retrieval with more setup and API cost.
- Compare the two on your own fixture; do not reuse the historical percentage.
- But 25-min setup + LLM cost

10.5. Q5. Where do I leave feedback?

GitHub Discussions Feedback category: <https://github.com/treylom/ThisCode/discussions/categories/feedback>

A 5-question schema, 2 minutes to answer → it feeds into the v1.1 graduate decision.

Need more help?

- GitHub Issues: <https://github.com/treylom/ThisCode/issues>
- Community: GitHub Discussions
- Docs: SETUP.md (for developers) / AGENTS.md (Custom Hybrid v1.0 spec) / BENCHMARK.md (interpreting the 5 axes)